

MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.

ROLE

THE MANAGER AS COACH

What coaching by a manager is and is not, what the research can and cannot show, and how a short weekly conversation can carry it.



16%

of nearly 15,000 employees said the last conversation with their manager was extremely meaningful.

GALLUP, 2023

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Being a good coach comes first on Google's list of what its best managers do, and Gallup calls the change every manager has to make “from boss to coach”. This issue is about what that means in a normal week.

Gallup finds that few conversations with a manager feel meaningful, and that short weekly ones count more than long rare ones. Google teaches its managers four questions, known as GROW. Two meta-analyses show that coaching at work has clear effects, but they leave out the manager who coaches their own team. That part of the evidence is still to be written, and every manager can add a line to it.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

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HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure

Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading

Where the editors interpret rather than the research, it says so.

Practice

The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

From boss to coach

When Google studied what its best managers do, being a good coach came first on the list. Google writes that it was one of the most important behaviours of its highest-scoring managers.

In 2019 Gallup's Jim Clifton and Jim Harter called the change “from boss to coach”. In Google's and Gallup's guidance, coaching is not a second job as trainer or therapist. It is a short, regular conversation in which the manager asks more than they tell, and the person chooses the next step.

The boss

Gives the answer

Checks the result at the end

Talks about what went wrong



1992

Coaching for Performance makes the GROW model known.



2016

Meta-analysis: coaching at work has clear effects.

The coach

Asks the question

Talks briefly, every week

Starts from recent work and strengths



2019

Gallup: the manager moves from boss to coach.



2023

Gallup: one meaningful conversation a week.

OUR READING

A boss gives the answer. A coach asks the question that lets the person find it, and then holds them to it.

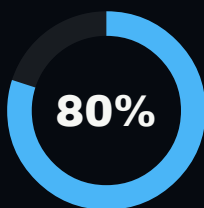
Sources: Google re:Work, 2018; Google re:Work, 2026; Jim Clifton & Jim Harter, Gallup Press, 2019; John Whitmore, 1992; Rebecca J. Jones, Stephen A. Woods & Yves R. F. Guillaume, Journal of Occupational and Organizational Psychology, 2016; Gallup, 2023

The comparison is our summary of Google's and Gallup's guidance.

THE NUMBERS

The conversation that counts

Gallup asked nearly 15,000 employees about the last conversation with their manager. Only 16% called it extremely meaningful.



of employees who received meaningful feedback in the past week are fully engaged.

In Gallup's findings, conversations of 15 to 30 minutes have more impact than conversations of 30 to 60, if they happen every week. A manager who skips weeks needs longer conversations to catch up.

WHAT MAKES A CONVERSATION MEANINGFUL: GALLUP'S FIRST TWO

- | | | |
|-----------|----------------------|-------------------------------|
| 01 | Recognition | for recent work |
| 02 | Collaboration | and relationships in the team |

Goals and priorities, and the person's strengths, are also on the list. Weaknesses are the least meaningful topic, perhaps because in many conversations they are the only one.

OUR READING

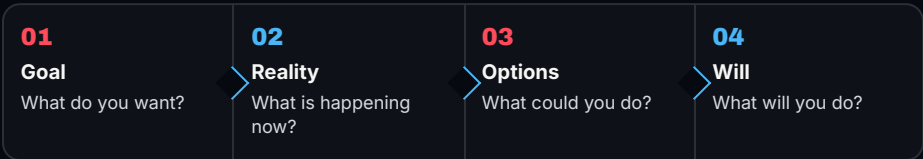
Short and every week beats long and rare. The conversation does not need a meeting room; it needs a fixed place in the week.

Source: Gallup, 2023

THE MODEL

Four questions

GROW became known through John Whitmore's Coaching for Performance in 1992. Google uses it to teach its managers coaching conversations and calls it a simple framework developed in the United Kingdom.



Google's guide says GROW works best when the person wants coaching and chooses the topic. The manager asks open questions, listens, and stops giving advice so that the person chooses the next step: less the one who fixes, more the one who makes it easier.

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, A SHIFT LEAD AND A NEW TEAM MEMBER

Goal	To close the shift on time
Reality	Two of the last five shifts ran 40 minutes over
Options	Start the handover earlier, ask for help sooner, prepare the counts in the quiet hour
Will	Counts at 20:00, for two weeks

The manager asked; the person chose. The example is invented.

OUR READING

The hardest question for a manager is not one of the four. It is the silence after the third one, when the answer is on the tip of your tongue.

Sources: John Whitmore, 1992; Google re:Work, 2026

The questions are Google's (re:Work); the translation is ours.

More in the essay

How to talk to someone who made a mistake

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

What coaching changes

Two meta-analyses bring together the controlled studies of coaching at work. Both find clear positive effects, and both leave out the manager who coaches their own team.

EFFECT OF WORKPLACE COACHING, 17 STUDIES (Δ)

Overall



Skills



Attitudes and feelings



Individual results



Jones, Woods and Guillaume (2016) left out coaching by the manager and by peers, and found stronger effects with internal than with external coaches. Theeboom, Beersma and van Vianen (2014, 18 studies) found effects from $g = 0.43$ to 0.74 , with trained coaches who had no formal authority over the person.

OUR READING

For the manager as coach, the best evidence is still correlation: Gallup's surveys and Google's own data. That is a reason to measure your own team, not a reason to stop.

Sources: Rebecca J. Jones, Stephen A. Woods & Yves R. F. Guillaume, *Journal of Occupational and Organizational Psychology*, 2016; Tim Theeboom, Bianca Beersma & Annelies E. M. van Vianen, *Journal of Positive Psychology*, 2014

δ and g are effect sizes; by the usual convention 0.2 is small, 0.5 medium and 0.8 large.

HOW IT IS MEASURED

Fifteen minutes a week

Gallup describes five coaching conversations, from a few minutes to a review that looks back and ahead. The weekly one decides whether the others work.

01	Role and relationship	expectations and how you work together, at the start and when the role changes
02	Quick connect	a few minutes, every week
03	Check-in	a longer look at progress and obstacles
04	Developmental coaching	around a project or a skill
05	Progress review	looking back and ahead, a few times a year

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, A TEAM OF EIGHT

Team	8 people
Weekly conversation	20 minutes per person
Total	2 h 40 min a week

About the length of one long meeting. The numbers are invented.

OUR READING

Fifteen minutes is not much time. Fifty weeks of fifteen minutes is a working relationship.

Sources: Gallup, 2020; Gallup, 2023

The names of the five conversations are Gallup's; the descriptions are our summary. The example is the editors'.

TOOL OF THE WEEK

The GROW card

One card for one conversation. The person chooses the topic; you ask the four questions and write down only what they decide.

01 Topic chosen by the person

02 Goal what do you want?

03 Reality what is happening now?

04 Options what could you do?

05 Will what will you do, and by when?

06 Next conversation date

A practice proposed by the editors, with Google's GROW questions. The card belongs to the person, not to a file.

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

Following the data: The research behind great managers

Google re:Work, 2018

<https://rework.withgoogle.com/intl/en/guides/following-the-data-the-research-behind-great-managers>

Coach using the GROW model

Google re:Work, 2026

<https://rework.withgoogle.com/intl/en/guides/coach-using-the-grow-model>

Coaching for Performance

John Whitmore, 1992

It's the Manager: Moving From Boss to Coach

Jim Clifton & Jim Harter, Gallup Press, 2019

<https://www.gallup.com/itsthemanager/>

A Great Manager's Most Important Habit

Gallup, 2023

<https://www.gallup.com/workplace/505370/great-manager-important-habit.aspx>

The effectiveness of workplace coaching: a meta-analysis of learning and performance outcomes from coaching

Rebecca J. Jones, Stephen A. Woods & Yves R. F. Guillaume, Journal of Occupational and Organizational Psychology, 2016

<https://doi.org/10.1111/joop.12119>

Does coaching work? A meta-analysis on the effects of coaching on individual level outcomes in an organizational context

Tim Theeboom, Bianca Beersma & Annelies E. M. van Vianen, Journal of Positive Psychology, 2014

<https://doi.org/10.1080/17439760.2013.837499>

5 Coaching Conversations (Called to Coach)

Gallup, 2020

<https://www.gallup.com/cliftonstrengths/en/296192/coaching-conversations-role-relationship-orientation.aspx>

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what exactly it measures. Where the publisher's page could not be opened, the figure was checked against independent summaries and is marked “via”. The editors' interpretation is marked “Our reading”. Figures that could not be confirmed are not in the issue.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.

Every week, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

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